

What is social media?

Though it might seem like a recent concept, social media is really the world wide web's version of a town square. Social media creates virtual places where people can interact with each other.

SEE ALSO

◀ 18–19 Computing with others

◀ 150–151 The internet and the world wide web

Social media platforms 196–197 ▶

Sharing content 198–199 ▶

Using social media

Social media platforms or social networks are websites and apps that allow users to connect to each other. They also allow users to upload their own content in the form of text, images, audio, and video. There is a variety of social media platforms, and each has its own flavour in terms of how it works and what it is centred around. Since their inception in the early 2000s, social media platforms have become more and more a part of everyday life.

“The **internet** is becoming the **town square** for the **global village** of tomorrow”.

Bill Gates (b. 1955),

American co-founder of Microsoft

◀ Business

Many businesses pay social media companies to spread the word of their products and services on social media platforms. Social media allows for people to share and like the things they see, which helps businesses to reach new customers.

▶ Entertainment

All kinds of entertainment are available on social media, from watching videos and participating in debates, to playing computer games with others.

◀ Building community

It has become fairly easy for people to find others with similar interests in their local area through social media.

◀ User-generated content

The lifeblood of social media is the ability for users to create their own content. Users upload images, video, or text, usually by using their smartphones.

